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REVIEW OF THE
OLYMPICS

CHASING MOUNT 90

Neeraj Chopra vows to continue his pursuit of the **elusive 90m mark**, as he prepares to overcome the recurring groin injury that has become an irritable thorn in the flesh for the Olympic champion.

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Neeraj Chopra was assured of a podium finish by the time he loaded his sixth and final attempt at the Lausanne Diamond League. However, there was still something far greater at stake.

As the javelin floated over the Stade Olympique de la Pontais, Neeraj was already indulging in his preferred routine. With his back turned to the flying neon-coloured shaft and arms spread skyward in an embrace, Neeraj was convinced he had done it. This celebration has become a common fixture during all his landmark throws, including at the Tokyo Olympics and the Budapest

World Championships.

The javelin landed on the 89.49m mark, just 51 centimeters shy of 90 metres. Even though Neeraj actually needed 67 centimeters more to take first place from Anderson Peters, those 51 centimeters would have sufficed for him.

"I have left it to the Almighty. Just work hard, prepare, and give it your best; after that, whatever has to happen will happen. The 90-metre target has been talked about so much now that I have decided to let it be," Neeraj said.

Neeraj is India's only Olympic medallist in athletics. He is the reigning world and Asian champion. The Diamond League crown in 2022 meant his trophy cabinet was unblemished. The 90m throw is merely a collector's item at this point. But the heart wants what it wants, and Neeraj, too, is human after all.

While he may downplay the need to achieve the elusive 90m throw, Neeraj is still fighting a recurring groin injury as he tries to prolong his season and take a shot at it.

"The injury is fine. It usually gets worse after competition, but this time Ishan [Marwaha] *bhai* treated me in Paris. I would like to thank him. The final treatment will be after the season ends. There is just one month left. I will try to take care of it as much as possible and consult the doctors later," Neeraj said.

Such is Neeraj's artistry that a layman fails to notice the physical handicap he has been operating with. Such are his ridiculously high standards that people expect him to deliver nonetheless. In fact, two of his three personal best attempts, including the 89.45m throw at the Paris Olympics, were made while enduring the discomfort of his injury.

"I did not think for a second that I could not go that far [Arshad Nadeem's throw of 92.97 metres]. It is not too difficult to get those two or three extra metres if you get the angle of release right. Even Arshad had a best of 90.18 before this, mine was 89.94. He got those two metres all of a sudden, and it wasn't that I couldn't. Again, with the groin injury,

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